WHILE WE'RE HERE



SMALL ESSAYS ON ATTENTION, TIME, AND BEING ALIVE

ADAM HICKEY

WHILE WE'RE HERE

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While We're Here

Small essays on attention, time, and being alive

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For my parents, who taught me to look,
and for Fabiola, who looks with me

These are small essays about being alive, written mostly on foot.

They aren't attempts to win an argument. I have gotten steadily less interested in being right and steadily more interested in noticing things, which is a poor strategy for winning discussions and a good one for most of the rest of it.

Mostly I wanted to know one thing. How much is going on in a familiar room, or on a walk I have taken a thousand times, that I have simply stopped being able to see?

You can read this from the beginning. You can also open it anywhere, read four pages, and put it down. It was built to survive both.

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Part I

Look Again

Nothing in this part is unfamiliar.
That is the whole of the difficulty.

Attention, beauty, and the case for the ordinary day.



Most of Life Is a Tuesday

Almost everything happens between the moments we think are important — and attention decides whether we notice.

THE DOG MOVED TWICE THIS AFTERNOON AND NEVER WOKE. THE SUN CAME IN LOW AND CROSSED HALF THE FLOOR BETWEEN TWO AND FIVE, AND THE DOG CROSSED WITH IT — A SLOW PURSUIT CONDUCTED ENTIRELY IN SLEEP. I MEASURED IT ONCE, OUT OF CURIOSITY. ABOUT A METER AN HOUR. THAT IS THE HONEST RECORD OF THE DAY, AND I HAVE STARTED TO SUSPECT THAT DAYS LIKE THIS ONE ARE NOT THE PACKAGING AROUND MY LIFE. THEY ARE THE SUBSTANCE.

9 MIN

The Life Between the Milestones

Most of life does not happen during the big moments. It happens in between them.

Not at the wedding, but on a Tuesday night years later when you're both tired and deciding what to eat. Not on the vacation, but while making coffee before work. Not at the graduation, but during the thousands of ordinary mornings that follow.

We organize our memories around events. Birthdays. Trips. Weddings. New jobs. Moves. Achievements. These become the chapter headings.

But chapter headings are not the book. The book is everything that happens between them. If you live for eighty years, only a tiny fraction of that time will contain anything you would call extraordinary. If happiness requires extraordinary circumstances, then happiness is necessarily rare. But if ordinary experience can become meaningful, almost your entire life becomes available.

A response that declines to something harmless repeating is called habituation, and it is one of the most widely observed forms of learning there is — described in animals with no brain at all. It also reverses. Change the stimulus and the response comes back.

Which sounds like consolation, and isn't. It is a claim about noticing, and I can tell you the afternoon I stopped believing it was a figure of speech.

There is a maple on the corner of my street that I did not see for eleven years.

I don't mean I never looked at it. I walked under it most mornings. I would have told you, if you had asked, that I knew the street well. Then one October afternoon I stopped in front of it, and it was enormous, and it had been enormous the entire time.

Nothing about the tree had changed. Something about me had.



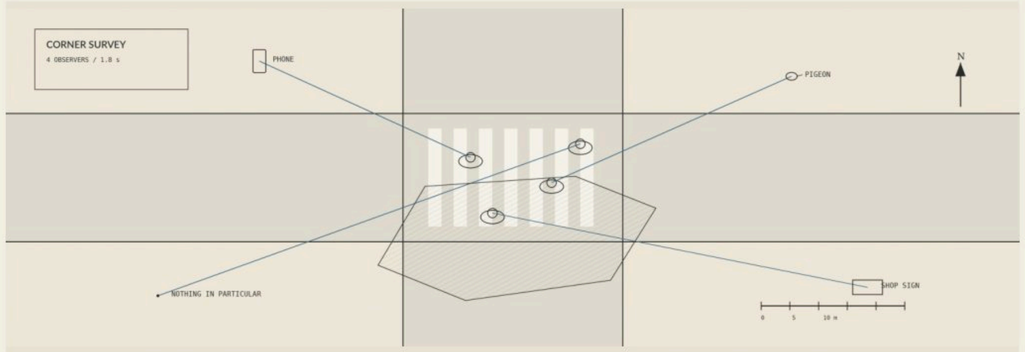


The Editor You Did Not Hire

We talk about attention as though it were a flashlight. You point it, it illuminates, and the world sits there patiently waiting to be lit. The model is flattering. It is also mostly wrong.

Attention isn't a beam. It is closer to an editor. It decides, many times a second and almost entirely without consulting you, what gets to count as the world.

The room you are sitting in contains more than you could ever process: the temperature of the air on the back of your hands, the particular pitch of the refrigerator, the fact that the light has moved four inches since you sat down. Your attention is not receiving that room. It is writing a very short summary of it and handing you the summary.



You have never once experienced a room. You have experienced a paraphrase.

Most of the time the paraphrase is excellent. It keeps you from walking into traffic and lets you find your keys. Brains economize: whatever repeats and stays harmless gets filed as background — the refrigerator hum, the commute, eventually the whole street. You would be overwhelmed if every texture and face and background sound felt as intense on the thousandth encounter as it did on the first.

But the same machinery that filters refrigerator noise also filters our lives. The person you love becomes familiar. Your home becomes familiar. Your body becomes familiar. Even being alive becomes familiar.



Who Is Directing the Editor

And what is familiar starts to look unimportant.

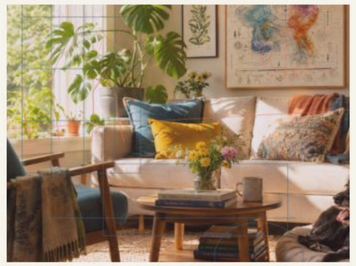
Which raises a question I find genuinely uncomfortable. If attention is doing the editing, who is directing the editor?

For most of human history the answer was: your body, and the weather. Hunger. Cold. Movement at the edge of a field. Another person's face.

In the last twenty years an entire industry has been built on the discovery that the editor takes suggestions. Not orders. Suggestions. A notification is a suggestion.

An autoplay is a suggestion. A feed is ten thousand suggestions arranged in the order most likely to be taken.

I don't think this is evil, exactly. I think it is the most successful engineering project of our lifetime, and I think it worked. The evidence isn't that we are distracted; distraction is ancient, and monks complained about it in writing. The evidence is that we have stopped noticing what we are distracted *from*.



The room, and the summary of it.

There is a particular exhaustion that comes at the end of a day of total engagement with nothing. You put the phone down at eleven and cannot name one thing you actually attended to. It wasn't rest and it wasn't work. It was consumption without digestion.

An older trap keeps us from the present just as well, and more quietly. We are constantly encouraged to imagine happiness as an event. Something happens, and then you feel different. You get the house. Reach the goal. Take the trip. Finally have enough time. The future contains the life you're trying to reach, and the present becomes transportation — a bridge between where you are and where you're supposed to be.

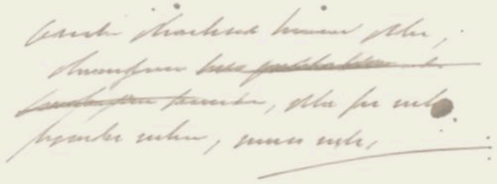
In a study that logged real use rather than asking about it, people checked their phones around eighty-five times a day. Their own estimates came to roughly half that, and the gap between the two is itself the finding.

Slowness Is the Only Method

The danger is that you can spend decades crossing bridges. Every destination eventually becomes another starting point. You arrive, the mind adjusts, and almost immediately life begins pointing somewhere else.

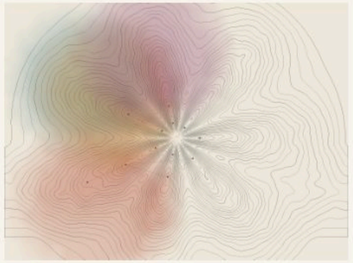
Children have not yet learned this. A child can spend twenty minutes watching water move through a gutter. A stick becomes an object worth carrying home. The world hasn't been divided so aggressively into important and unimportant things. Adults become efficient instead. We've seen the tree before. We know what rain is. Familiarity lets us move faster, and moving faster is how the tree gets lost.

Here is the part I keep returning to. Attention is trainable, but not by force.



You cannot decide to notice more the way you decide to answer an email. I have tried, with the enthusiasm of a man who solves things. Concentration can be forced; it responds to deadlines and coffee and fear. Noticing cannot. It arrives or it doesn't. What you can do is arrange the conditions in which it becomes likely, and nearly all of those conditions turn out to be versions of the same thing, which is slowness.

Walking works. Sitting still works. Ten minutes in front of one painting works better than a museum. Boredom works, though nobody wants to hear it. Grief works, unfortunately, and thoroughly. So does a dog, who will stop at the same square yard of grass every day for nine years and never once find it uninteresting.

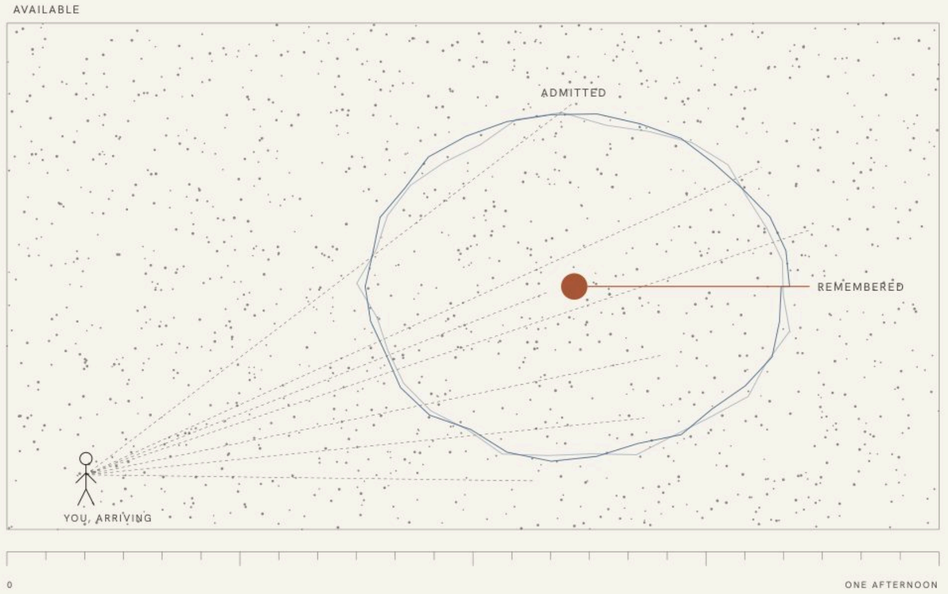


The corner maple as contour lines — eleven years, drawn at once.

FIGURE 01.1

What the editor kept

Almost everything that happens near you is discarded before you meet it. This is not a flaw. A version of you that admitted the whole room would be unable to cross a street. But the ratios are worth looking at once. They are drawn, not measured, but something like them is the shape of a life.



Available. Everything the room was actually doing while you were in it.

Admitted. The fraction that reached awareness at all.

Remembered. The fraction you will still have tomorrow.



Figure 1. A bare wall, a window out of frame, and a scatter of colored light between them. She has the room to herself and is not doing anything with it.

Walking, sitting still, boredom and the dog have one thing in common. They lower the speed of the world until the detail can catch up with you.

The maple was not a revelation. It was the ordinary result of standing still for ninety seconds on a street I usually crossed in twenty.

This is also why repetition gets a worse reputation than it deserves. We imagine a meaningful life as a sequence of new experiences. But repetition may be exactly what allows subtle differences to become visible.

On my usual route there is one tree I have photographed four times now — same tree, same angle, one photograph a season. Anyone watching would have seen a man standing in the street doing nothing. The tree never once repeated itself.

The Route Repeats

The light changes. Birds arrive and leave. A house gets painted. Someone who used to walk beside you no longer does.

The route repeats. The world does not.

A routine is a stable frame around constant change. The morning coffee is similar; you aren't. The neighborhood looks similar; it isn't. Even your body is continuously rebuilding itself. The apparently static world is moving everywhere, just slowly enough that distraction mistakes it for stillness.

We do the same thing to people that we do to streets. We turn them into categories — wife, husband, mother, father, friend, coworker — and the label makes someone familiar enough that we occasionally stop seeing the person underneath it. But every person around us contains an entire private universe. Memories you'll never see. Things they notice when you're not there. Childhood versions of themselves. Internal conversations.



The label, and the person underneath it.

A person you've known for thirty years remains fundamentally mysterious. That mystery can disappear beneath routine. Romantic love often begins with novelty — everything about the person is interesting, how they laugh, what they eat. Then years pass, and the extraordinary person becomes the person standing in the kitchen. Maybe mature love is partly remembering that those are the same person.

William James, writing more than a century before any of this was engineered, argued that a life is made of whatever a person consents to notice. He meant it as psychology. It reads now as an inventory.

Attention is the only genuinely nonrenewable thing you have. Money comes back. Energy comes back. Even time comes back, in the sense that tomorrow arrives whether or not you have earned it. Attention does not work that way. Every minute of it is spent in the moment it is spent, and the sum of those minutes is not a metaphor for your life. It is your life, in the most literal accounting available.

The Only Nonrenewable Thing

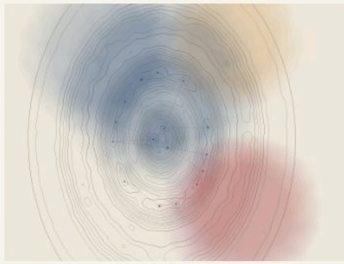
This should probably produce anxiety. Mostly it produces the opposite in me.

If attention is the currency, then the price of a good day is far lower than I was led to believe. I have had genuinely extraordinary experiences that I barely registered — arranged at expense, photographed carefully, and gone. I have also had ten minutes on a back step with a cup of coffee, watching a bird do something idiotic in a gutter, that I can still see with total clarity a decade later.

The difference was not the quality of the events. It was whether I showed up for them.

We spend enormous effort trying to make our lives more interesting. Very little of it goes into becoming more interested. These are not the same project, and only one of them is available this afternoon.

None of which requires appreciating every second. That would become another form of self-improvement — now you must optimize gratitude too. Ordinary life includes irritation, boredom, laundry, work you don't want to do, arguments. A meaningful life doesn't need every moment to feel meaningful. It may simply require understanding that these moments belong to the same life as the extraordinary ones. The boring afternoon isn't interrupting your life. It is your life.



The lake, surveyed as weather.

There will always be extraordinary moments, and they matter. Travel somewhere beautiful. Fall in love. Make something you're proud of. Then you come down, and you make breakfast.

Because eventually, when we look backward, I suspect much of what we'll want won't be another accomplishment.

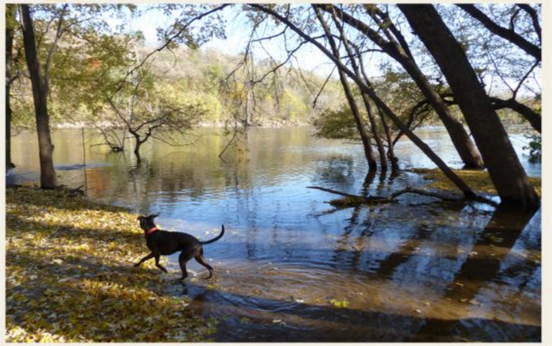
One more dinner. One more walk. One more morning in the old house. One more chance to hear somebody come through the door. One more afternoon when nothing happened.

The world didn't change. Your attention did. I think about that most days now, usually badly, usually while checking something I do not need to check. But I know where the maple is, and some mornings I look up.

Eleven years is a long time to walk under something beautiful.

Maybe the ordinary days were the important parts.

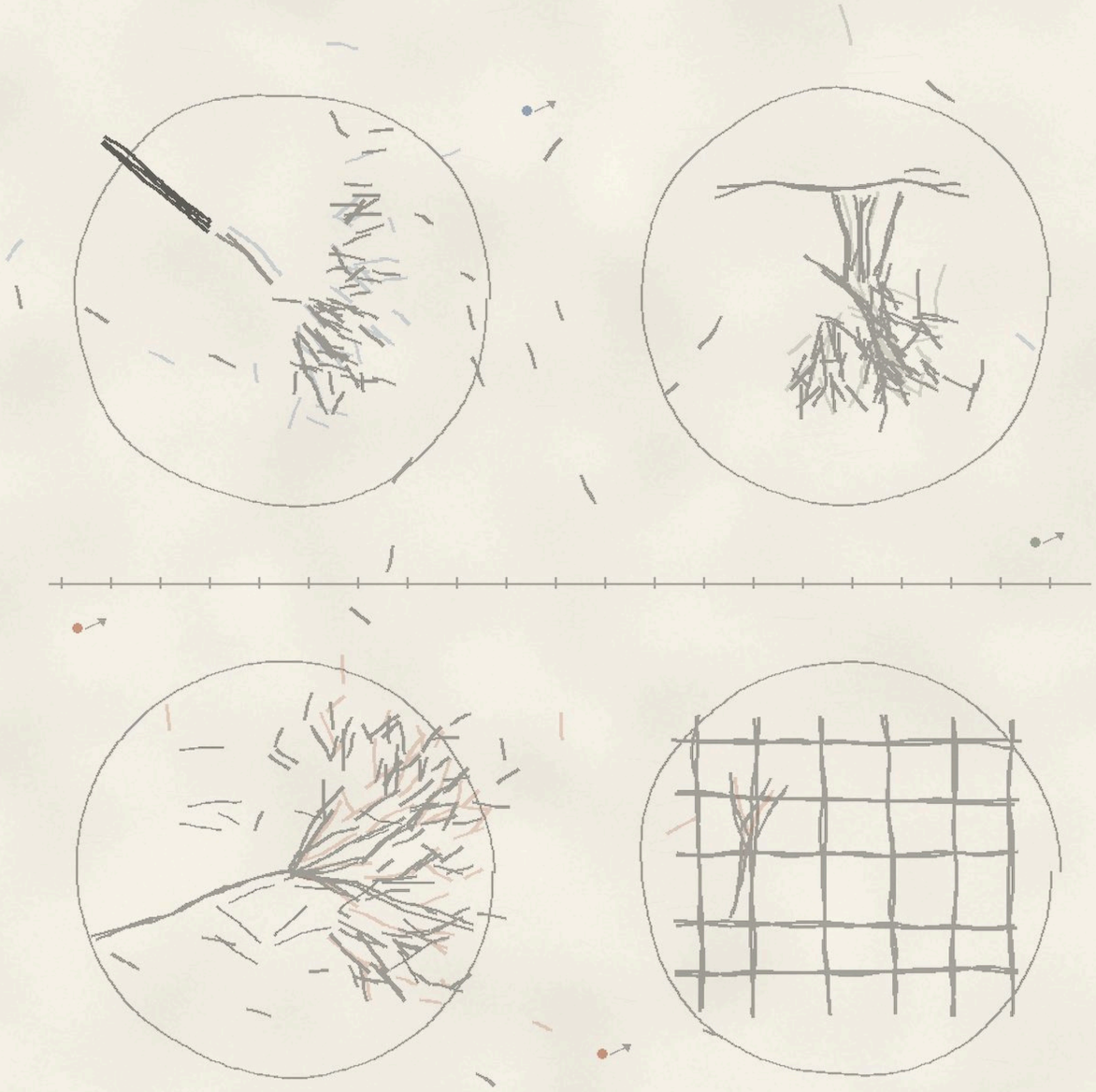
We just didn't know what they were worth yet.





nothing happening

I had nearly walked past before the small movements separated themselves from the view. The mooring lines lifted, slackened, and pulled tight again. Water pressed against the dock in short runs. A loose line tapped one mast, stopped, then started after the next wave. The boats shifted by inches and returned. I stood there long enough for the same motions to repeat without becoming identical. The bright patch beneath the hulls kept breaking into pieces and joining itself again.



Part II

What Are We?

The order was never installed. It is being held in place, continuously, by things that cannot see it.

Flocks, networks, nests, and the intelligence that is not in your head.



Nobody Is Holding the Drawing

Order can arrive without a plan when many small parts keep answering one another — and so can a thought.

A COLONY WORKS BEHIND GLASS AT THE END OF THE BARN. EACH BEE STOPS AT CELL AFTER CELL, TOUCHES THE RIM, AND MOVES ON. ONE BACKS OUT AND REVERSES DOWN THE COMB. TWO MEET HEAD TO HEAD, PASS ANTENNAE, AND SEPARATE. FROM STANDING HEIGHT THE SHEET LOOKS PLANNED. CAPPED HONEY IS BANKED ALONG THE TOP, THE BROOD IS HELD IN THE WARM MIDDLE, AND THE EMPTY CELLS WAIT AT THE EDGE. THERE IS NO BEE AT THE FRONT HOLDING A DRAWING. NONE CAN SEE THE WHOLE COMB. THE WALL EXISTS BECAUSE THOUSANDS OF SMALL BODIES KEEP WORKING THE SAME SURFACE AND ANSWERING WHAT THE LAST ONE LEFT.

9 MIN

Looking for the Maker

We are trained to look for the maker. A nest suggests an architect. A flock suggests a leader. A network suggests a plan drawn somewhere before the first connection was made. This habit works well for tables and bridges. It fails in much of the living world. The order appears first in the interactions. Each part follows a narrow set of conditions. Nearness is maintained. Collisions are avoided. A turn spreads when nearby bodies turn. No part understands the final form. There is no final inspection and no moment when the system sees itself completed. The form is what those instructions become when they are repeated by many bodies over time.

A starling responds to a fixed number of near neighbors rather than to everything within a fixed distance, which is why a flock keeps its shape as it stretches and compresses.

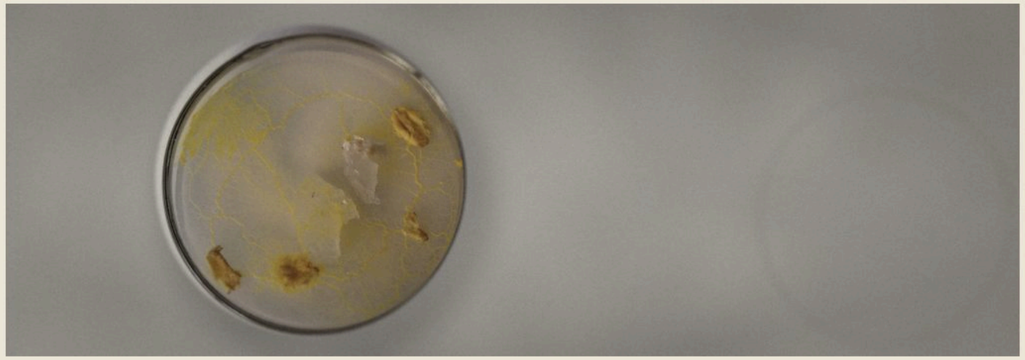
A flock of European starlings can turn through the winter sky as if it were one dark sheet being folded. The birds do not all watch a single leader. Each responds to a small number of nearby birds. A turn begins somewhere and travels across the flock faster than any one bird could inspect the whole shape. The pattern has no fixed center. Birds enter, leave, trade positions, and continue to produce a coherent edge. What looks like an object is a temporary agreement among moving animals. The flock is not controlled from above. It is held together from beside.



Held together from beside.

A Body Solving Only What Touches It

The same logic can be seen in a yellow slime mold spread across a laboratory dish. *Physarum polycephalum* has no brain and no nervous system. It extends thin tubes toward food, reinforces the routes that carry material efficiently, and withdraws from routes that do not. Researchers placed food at positions corresponding to cities around Tokyo. The organism built a network with costs and resilience comparable to the rail system. Thick tubes remained along useful connections. Redundant branches thinned and disappeared. It did not know Tokyo. It did not know railways. It answered gradients of food, light, and its own internal flow. A useful map emerged from a body solving only the conditions touching it.



The honeycomb looks drafted. Its repeating cells divide a surface into chambers of similar size, and the geometry tempts us to imagine a diagram passed through the hive. The bees have something smaller. New cells begin in the grooves between cells already built, and each one inherits its position from the neighboring work. The regularity is real, but it is not perfect. Cells bend near the edge. Rows adjust around obstacles. A misplaced cell changes the shapes around it. The comb is exact where exactness helps and flexible where the material requires it. Its beauty does not come from escaping those limits. The limits are what give the pattern its shape.

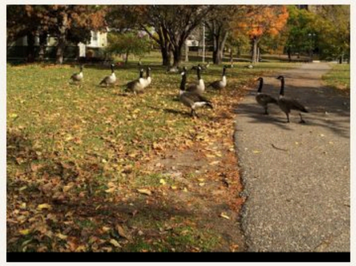
In a 2010 experiment, *Physarum polycephalum* was given food at positions matching cities around Tokyo. The network it built balanced cost, transport efficiency and fault tolerance at levels comparable to the rail system.

Nobody Drew the River

These systems are often called self-organizing, though the phrase can make them sound independent of the world around them. They are not. Water follows slope. Roots follow moisture and gaps in soil. A river basin takes its branching shape from rock, rain, gravity, vegetation, and the channels cut by earlier water. The map of a watershed is a record of resistance as much as flow. A harder ridge remains because water moved elsewhere. A new channel deepens because earlier water made the next passage easier. Nobody drew the river.

Human systems do this too. A footpath appears where enough people cut the same corner. A language shifts because millions of speakers shorten sounds, borrow terms, mishear phrases, and repeat what survives. A city grows around old property lines and routes to water, and later transit lines inherit those earlier choices. Nobody designed the total result, even when thousands of people designed pieces of it. The system carries intention without having a single intention of its own. That is why it can be useful, wasteful, durable, and difficult to change at the same time.

A line of ants crosses the pavement, thinner where the surface has cooled. A bicycle passes through it. For a few seconds the route is broken. Ants circle the gap and touch the ground with their antennae. Some return to the curb. Others find the trace on the far side. The line reforms, not exactly where it was, but close enough to reach the same opening. Nothing announces that the repair is complete. There is only movement where movement had stopped. The pattern persists by changing. The system survives because no single part contains it.

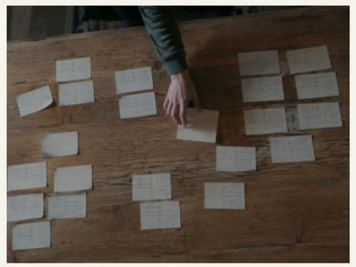


The path was poured for other feet.

The Web That Changed the Spider

An orb-weaving spider sits with its legs touching radial threads. Vibrations from prey, wind, or another spider travel through the web, and the spider can alter thread tension and change how those signals move. The web is not only a trap. It is an adjustable sensory surface built outside the animal's body. Part of the work of detection happens in silk before a signal reaches the nervous system. The spider made the structure, then the structure changed what the spider could perceive.

The same habit shows up a second time, with thinking. We look for the maker, and we also look for the thinker, as though every thought must happen entirely inside a head. The spider suggests otherwise. We do what it does every time we put a thought into a notebook, draw a diagram, or leave a tool arranged for tomorrow.



Index cards, grouped before the groups have names.

A pencil line crosses a pine board at thirty-seven and a quarter inches. The tape measure snaps shut. The number leaves working memory almost at once, but the line remains. A saw can now be placed against it without the measurement being repeated. The board is holding part of the task. The mark is not intelligent by itself. It does not know what is being built. Still, the cut would be less reliable without it. The thought has been divided between a nervous system and a surface. One remembers the intention. The other preserves the location.

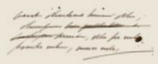


Figure 2. A muqarnas vault at the Alhambra: thousands of small cells stepping inward to one form. The essay's exception — this ceiling had a diagram.

Human attention is narrow. Under controlled conditions, the active part of working memory often holds about four chunks at once. The exact number changes with the task, but the limitation is plain in daily work. A long calculation becomes unstable when every intermediate result must be remembered. Put the figures on paper and the problem changes: earlier steps remain available while attention moves forward. Scrabble tiles can be moved until a word appears. Index cards can be grouped before the categories have names. The hands make a possibility visible, then the eyes return it to the brain. Thinking continues through the loop.

What Tools Remember

Tools do more than increase force. They carry instructions. The bubble in a spirit level turns gravity into a readable position. A kitchen scale converts pressure into a number that can be compared with a recipe. The shape of a key preserves a solution to a lock. None of these devices decides the larger purpose. Each narrows a difficult judgment into a condition that can be checked. Previous minds are present in the shape of the tool. Someone learned where a handle should bend, which edge needs a guard, and how much tolerance the material allows. That learning becomes available to a later user who may never know the history. The tool is a small archive made operational.



Groups have always kept knowledge in more than one head. One person remembers the names. Another remembers the sequence. A surgical team does not rely on one mind to contain the whole operation. Instruments are counted aloud. Readings remain visible. Roles are assigned so that one person's attention can catch what another misses. Reliable work is often produced by a system that distributes memory and verification across people and objects. Expertise still matters — the expert is partly the person who knows where the knowledge lives, when to call for it, and how to recognize a result that does not fit.



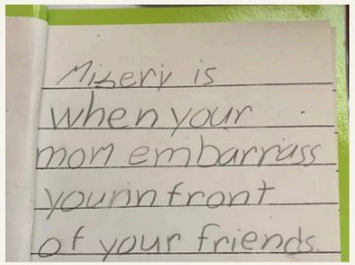
The number forgotten; the line kept.

Support, and Surrender

Language is the oldest way of keeping knowledge outside any one head. A word compresses distinctions learned by people who lived before the current speaker. Technical vocabulary can carry a procedure across decades. A place-name keeps an earlier use attached to a landscape after the building is gone. Writing makes the effect durable. Instructions survive their author. A margin note can argue with a reader born later. Libraries do not merely contain thoughts that once happened inside individual heads. They allow new thoughts to be assembled from records that no single person could have produced or retained. The intelligence belongs to the living reader, but the materials arrive from outside. Thinking is inheritance put back into motion.

Research on working memory finds a central capacity averaging about four chunks in adults, with the exact figure depending on the task and on what counts as a chunk.

Knowledge kept outside the head is powerful, and vulnerable for the same reason. A notebook can be lost, and a navigation database can be wrong. A checklist copied without understanding can preserve an old mistake with impressive consistency. Systems that make action easier can also hide the knowledge needed to question them. The answer is not to keep everything in memory; that has never been possible. The useful distinction is between support and surrender. A good external system leaves enough of its workings visible that a person can detect failure. The pencil line can be measured again.



Written by someone who is now the reader.

The cut board is carried to the frame and does not fit. The line was clear, but the measurement was wrong. The builder returns to the tape, the drawing, and the opening where the board belongs. Each holds a different part of the error. The corrected length emerges from comparing them. No single object contains the answer. No single glance completes the work. Intelligence appears in the traffic between memory and material. The mind reaches outward, receives resistance, and changes course. The room is not a backdrop for thought. It is one of the places where thought happens.

Every tool so far has held the thought it was given.

The next one answers back.





never been lost

The tag on her collar has a name on one side and a square code on the other. She was asleep when I checked it. The code opens a page with her photograph and a form for whoever finds her, and a note that says she is friendly, which is true. She has never been lost. The tag clicks against her bowl when she drinks. I scanned it once, standing in the kitchen, to see what would happen. Somewhere a server confirmed that she was not missing.



A dog with a URL.



Part III

The World Is Changing

You are inside the change, not after it. That is the only vantage point that ever exists.

Machines that are learning to think, and a world that has already stopped being the previous one.



The Strange Privilege

The rare condition is not living after a transformation, but living while its rules are still unsettled.

A MAN SITS FOR A PORTRAIT IN A STUDIO WITH A PAINTED BACKDROP BEHIND HIM. THE PHOTOGRAPHER CHOOSES THE MOMENT, AND NOBODY IN THE ROOM SEES THE RESULT. THE FILM LEAVES IN AN ENVELOPE AND COMES BACK WEEKS LATER AS A SET OF PRINTS IN SEVERAL SIZES. THERE IS ONE EXPRESSION, AND IT BECOMES THE WAY THIS FACE LOOKS TO EVERYONE WHO IS GIVEN A COPY. IT CANNOT BE CHECKED ON THE DRIVE HOME. IT CANNOT BE DELETED, FILTERED, OR QUIETLY REPLACED BY A BETTER FRAME FROM THE SAME AFTERNOON, BECAUSE THERE IS NO BETTER FRAME AND NO SAME AFTERNOON TO RETURN TO. COPIES GO TO RELATIVES WHO PUT THEM IN DRAWERS. THE PORTRAIT BELONGED TO A WORLD IN WHICH AN IMAGE COULD BE COMPLETE, PORTABLE, AND STILL UNABLE TO BE REVISED.

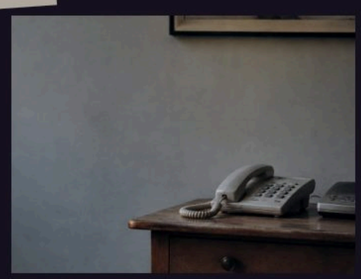
8 MIN

Written in 2026, while these rules were still unsettled.

No Single Day

There was no single day when that world ended. The before-time, the years before constant connection became normal, faded unevenly. A household could have a computer without an internet connection, then a slow connection that occupied the telephone line, then broadband in one room. A mobile phone might be carried for emergencies and kept switched off to preserve the battery. Some people lived online while their neighbors still mailed checks and waited for photographs to be developed. The boundary was never global. Access depended on income, infrastructure, age, and place, and even now the network does not reach everyone equally.

To leave home once meant becoming difficult to reach. A telephone rang in a particular building. If nobody answered, the caller tried later or left a message on a machine. Plans had to survive without continuous repair. A meeting place and time were agreed upon before anyone departed, and someone who ran late could not make lateness visible from the road. The others waited or left. This required more patience than the present system and caused more needless worry. It also created intervals when a person's attention was not open to distant requests. Absence was not a setting selected from a menu. It was what happened when a body moved beyond the length of a wire.



It waited, and so did everyone.

The Length of a Wire

Media carried the same delay. A roll of film held perhaps twenty-four or thirty-six exposures, and the image remained latent until the roll was finished, processed, and printed. By the time a blurred frame returned, the room had changed and the people had gone home. A missed broadcast might be missed completely. A library search ended where the shelves and catalog ended. Scarcity could be frustrating, especially when the needed fact was far away. It also gave each choice a visible cost. One photograph used one frame. A copy required time, material, and a machine close enough to make it.

Pew Research Center surveys found that 52 percent of U.S. adults used the internet in 2000. By 2025 the figure was 96 percent, though survey methods changed during that span.

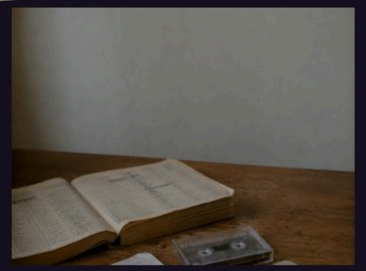
The network reduced those frictions in ways that are difficult to separate from daily competence. Directions adjust while the car moves. A family can see a child across an ocean. A medical result arrives without another trip to the clinic. Lost facts can be retrieved before an argument finishes. These are not small gains, and remembering the earlier world does not make it better. Nostalgia edits inconvenience with the same confidence that a phone edits a photograph. It removes the missed connection, the inaccessible record, and the person stranded without help. The before-time contained privacy and isolation in the same silence. The present contains connection and surveillance in the same device.



Time you could not fill from the road.

The Default Answer to Uncertainty

What changed most was not the number of screens. It was the default answer to uncertainty. A forgotten name once remained forgotten until someone remembered it. A disagreement could end with no verdict. The location of a friend was unknown unless the friend reported it. Now the first movement is toward a search field, a map, or a message, and the impulse arrives before the sentence has finished forming. This does not mean memory has failed. It means retrieval has become part of thought.



Things that did one thing each.

The people who remember both conditions are not defined by a birth year. They are a moving group whose members crossed the boundary at different ages. They learned to wait beside a landline, then learned to carry a device that made waiting optional. They memorized routes and wrote letters before navigation and messages became continuous services. This gives them no special wisdom. It gives them comparison. They can feel when a convenience replaces a skill, because both actions remain available in memory. They can also remember how quickly an awkward tool became a social requirement, then became almost invisible.

That comparison is the rare thing, and it is available again right now, as machines learn to write.

RECORD 1 OF 1

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Meta Platforms, "Advertisers using your activity or information". Personal data export generated 19 August 2026. Of the first 160 entries in export order, 154 are printed here unedited and unsorted; six are withheld. The 7,165 beyond them are not printed because they would fill this page forty-six times over.

A revolution is easiest to miss when it arrives as a convenience.

It Offers to Finish a Task Before Lunch

A blank field sits in the middle of a screen. A sentence is typed into it. The machine pauses, then begins returning words. They arrive at the speed of thought but without the hesitations of a person deciding what to say. Some are useful. One claim is wrong. The tone is almost right. A paragraph that might have taken an hour now exists in less than a minute and still needs to be read with care. Nothing in the room looks historic. There is a mug beside the keyboard and dust along the monitor stand. The event resembles office work.

That is how a technological revolution enters daily life. It does not announce the future. It offers to finish a task before lunch.



The machinery, disappeared behind a number.

Later generations inherit revolutions as furniture. Electric light becomes a switch on the wall. Recorded music becomes a button. Satellite navigation becomes a blue line that appears before the car moves. The machinery disappears behind a reliable action, and the long period of uncertainty is compressed into a date in a textbook. Living through the change feels different. Standards conflict. Devices fail in public. Old skills remain necessary while new ones become unavoidable. People argue about names because the categories have not settled. A tool can be called a toy for years, then become the place where ordinary work begins.

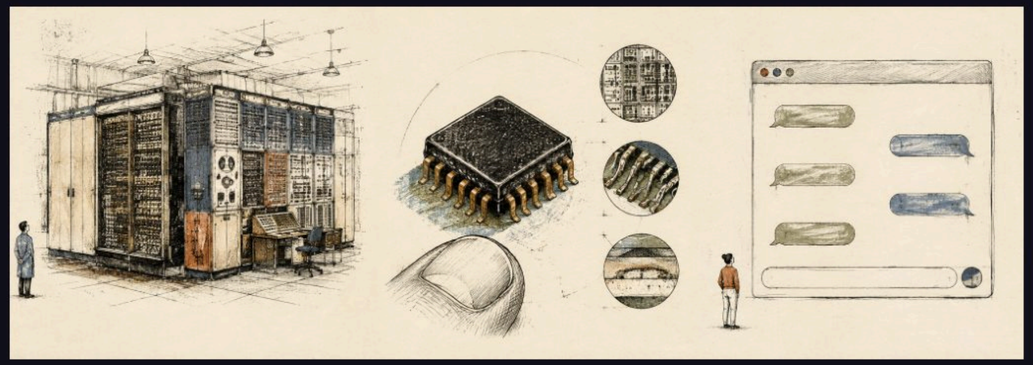


Figure 3. The dog under the desk. Whatever is happening above her is, from the floor, a Tuesday.

The weaknesses of the new tools are easy to meet, which is itself new. Earlier advances in machine learning arrived inside ranking systems and fraud detection, and their decisions affected daily life without presenting themselves as collaborators. Generative systems appeared in a blank field instead. A person could ask for a paragraph and watch an answer form. The same system that produces a clear explanation can invent a source. An image can preserve a difficult lighting condition and misunderstand a hand. Fluency and reliability arrive as separate properties, and the user has to learn the difference.

Fluency and Reliability Arrive Separately

For a short period, both conditions exist in the same room. The old way of working sits beside the new one, and professions change inside that overlap. A designer can produce more variations before a meeting. A programmer can begin with a proposed function instead of an empty file. Review becomes a larger part of the craft. Faster production can create room for judgment, or it can become the reason more production is demanded. The person who once made every first draft becomes responsible for detecting the subtle failure that an effortless draft conceals.



The costs are being built into everyday life at the same time. Large systems require concentrated computing power and vast collections of data. Their errors spread at the speed of copying. Synthetic evidence can be made cheaply, while trust remains slow to repair. A useful assistant can become an authority it has not earned. These are not objections from outside the revolution. They are part of its design. Every convenience establishes dependencies. Every interface decides what effort becomes invisible. Later, many of these choices will look natural, because they will be old.



Review becomes a larger part of the craft.

What a Museum Cannot Keep

The paragraph on the screen is selected and revised. A specific noun replaces a vague one. The unsupported claim is removed. One sentence remains exactly as the machine produced it, because it does the work cleanly. The final page contains no reliable way to separate the origins.



A format that outlived its machines.

And this comparison will fade, the same way the memory of the before-time is fading. Objects can be preserved, but the expectation around them is harder to display. A rotary telephone in a museum does not reproduce the experience of waiting beside it. A paper map does not restore a world in which nobody in the car could see the road ahead. The important artifact is the former rule. Calls happened at places. Photographs arrived later. Plans contained silence. Once the people who lived under those rules are gone, the objects remain as evidence without witnesses who remember their weight, and the condition becomes a style that can be imitated more easily than understood.

Home broadband was reported by 1 percent of U.S. adults in March 2000. Smartphone ownership rose from 35 percent in Pew's first 2011 survey to 91 percent in 2025.

The car reaches the next town without using the atlas. A phone has been giving directions from the cup holder, its voice arriving a few seconds before each turn. The paper map remains open anyway. Its route and the blue line agree for most of the distance. At one junction they divide. The driver follows the phone and passes a field that the old road never reached.

Nothing dramatic marks the change. This is how it ends in memory too — not with a closing date.

One system continues to work while another becomes unnecessary.

An old instruction, still legible beside a habit that no longer needs it.





Part IV

While We're Here

Nothing here is permanent.
Nothing here is therefore smaller.

Distance, arrival, ordinary rooms, and the time we get to spend in them together.



While We're Here

A place is reached by passing through the distance before it. So is a life.

A PUBLIC STAIR DROPS AWAY BETWEEN TWO HANDRAILS. THE SHADOW OF THE PERSON AT THE TOP LIES DOWN IT, ACROSS HALF THE FLIGHT. MOSS HAS COME IN AT BOTH EDGES AND STOPPED WHERE THE FEET BEGIN. EACH PERSON ARRIVED AT THE SAME LANDING, TOOK THE SAME FIRST STEP, AND WENT DOWN. NO SINGLE CROSSING CHANGED THE STAIR ENOUGH TO SEE. THE ROUTE IS VISIBLE AS THE STRIP THAT STAYED CLEAR.

9 MIN

The Strip That Stayed Clear

Much of life can be made faster now. The searching, the calculating, the drafting, sometimes the making, can be skipped. Some things still have to be lived at their own speed.

Pilgrimage begins with a plain fact. A place is reached by passing through the distance before it. Nothing requires walking it anymore. Whole systems exist so that nobody has to, and the strip on the stair stays clear anyway. The body cannot skip the hill just because the destination matters. It cannot arrive early by understanding the map. Shoes wear. Water is carried. Weather reaches the skin. An intention that began as a sentence is given weight, duration, and a series of surfaces.

Travel usually treats distance as a problem to reduce. Faster routes are preferred. Waiting is measured as lost time. The destination is the useful part, and the miles between are charged against it. Pilgrimage reverses that arrangement. The route is not an obstacle placed before the meaningful place. It is the method by which the place acquires meaning. A shrine reached after forty days is physically the same structure that could be reached by bus. The arrival is different because the traveler has spent forty mornings approaching it. Time has not been removed from the journey. It has been made into one of its materials.

The routes to Santiago de Compostela through France were inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List in 1998, a recognition of the road itself rather than only the destination.

Traditional pilgrimages give the movement a form. The Shikoku Henro circles an island through eighty-eight temples. The Camino de Santiago gathers many routes toward one city. Markers reduce the number of decisions. Stamps, repeated prayers, shared clothing, and named stages make progress countable. These rules do not make every pilgrim's purpose the same.

One person walks from religious obligation. Another walks after a death, a recovery, or a change that has not found words. The route can hold different reasons because it asks for the same next action. Wake, then walk to the next place. The larger question is carried without being solved at every step.



Progress, made countable.

A Measure That Cannot Be Argued With

The body supplies a measure that cannot be argued with for long. A blister changes pace. Heat decides when to stop. Hunger makes the next town more important than the distant end. This narrowing is part of what the walk is for. At home, a dozen smaller claims let a difficult thought be put off. On a long route, attention returns to water, grade, weather, and the next marker. The concern that began the journey remains present, but it loses the ability to occupy every minute. By evening, the walker has not escaped the question. The question has been placed among other facts.

The walking itself goes unnoticed, the way the most familiar things do. Weight shifts forward. One leg catches it, then the other. An enormous amount of calculation is performed without asking permission, and a person crosses the ground while thinking about something else entirely. It is an astonishing biological achievement, and almost nobody experiences it as one.



The distance, seen all at once.

Pilgrimage is also built by strangers. Historic routes required wells, bridges, hospitals, and places to sleep. Towns learned the rhythm of arriving feet. Food was prepared for people who would leave the next morning. A route becomes durable when hospitality is repeated along it. The walker depends on people who did not begin the journey and may not share its reason. This dependence is easy to overlook in accounts centered on private transformation. The path is a social structure. Someone maintains the marker. Someone recognizes the tired person at the door. Solitude on a pilgrimage is supported by a long chain of other people's work.



A Long Chain of Other People's Work

Religious pilgrimage gives the long walk a sacred destination, but the human pattern appears elsewhere. People walk to a childhood home before it is sold. They travel to a battlefield, a grave, or the coast where a migration began. A runner returns to the same long race each year. The destinations differ in seriousness, but the structure is recognizable. In each case, the person needs a place to help say what words alone cannot.

Effort creates a boundary around the visit. The person arrives having paid in time rather than simply having appeared.

None of which the road owes anybody. Distance does not make a person wise, and pain is not automatically meaningful. What the route supplies is conditions. Progress becomes slow enough to notice. Dependence becomes visible. A purpose has to survive boredom and bad weather. The traveler can still arrive unchanged. Even then, the miles were real.



Arrival needs a fixed edge. Without one, a long walk dissolves into mileage. A gate, a square, a plain stone: the route is given somewhere to stop, and people touch the surface or sit down without knowing what action belongs next. The destination usually looks smaller than the anticipation surrounding it, which is useful. It cannot contain every reason brought toward it. It only marks that the distance has been completed.



Crossing after dark, one ordinary step at a time.

The Same Pavement as Errands

The yellow arrow points through a residential street where laundry moves above parked cars. Nothing in the lane announces that it belongs to an ancient route. A walker follows it past a bakery and a road crew lifting stones. Pilgrimage does not remove ordinary life from the path. It threads purpose through it. The sacred route uses the same pavement as errands and deliveries.

A life is laid out the same way. Whatever it is for runs through the same days as the errands.



Arrival needs a fixed edge.

Against the whole of time, one life is a narrow bracket. Before it, the lake froze and opened without us. Roads were laid along older paths. Languages arrived through mouths that are gone. After it, the same systems will continue in altered forms. This scale can make one life look negligible, but size and importance are not the same measurement. A small interval can contain every person a person knows, every room remembered, and every choice that changed the next day. The bracket is not an error in the larger timeline. It is the only section available for experience. Its limits do not make its contents less real. They give the contents a location.

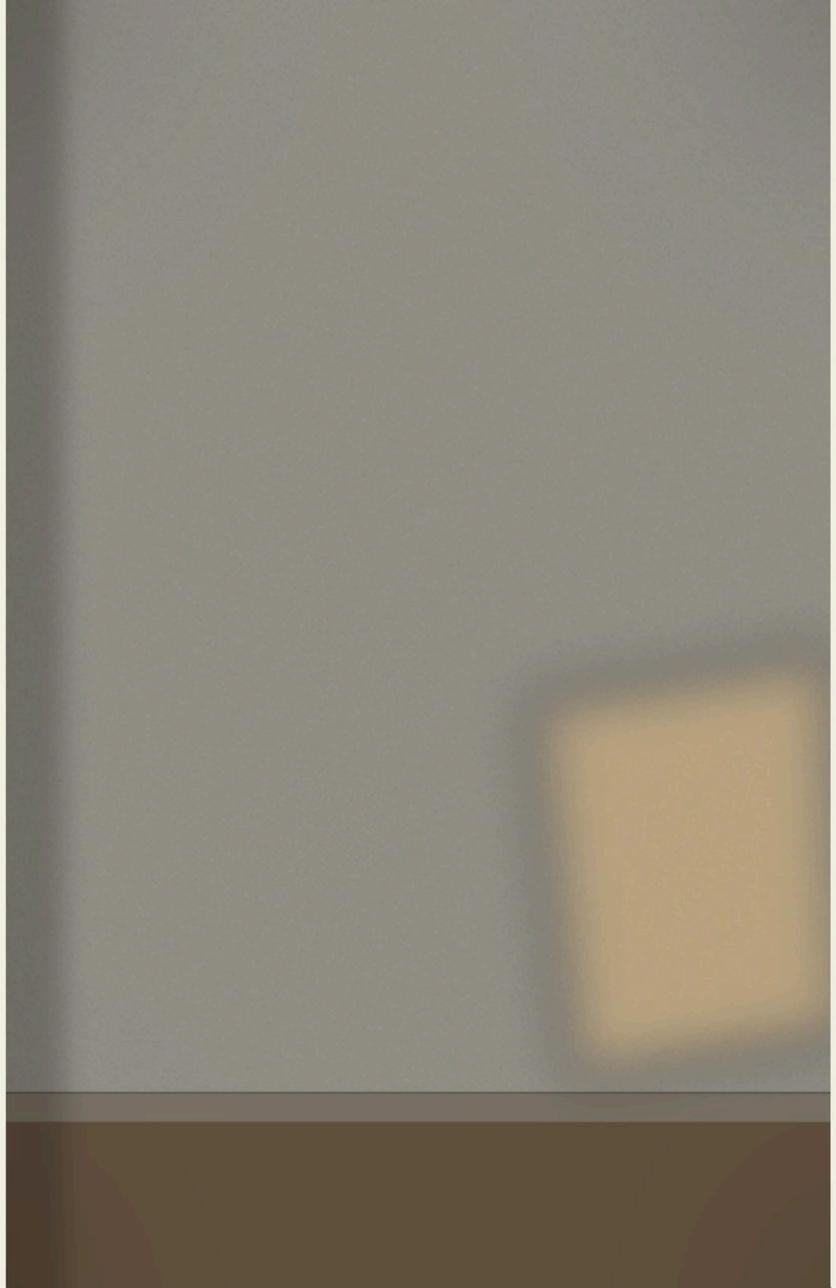
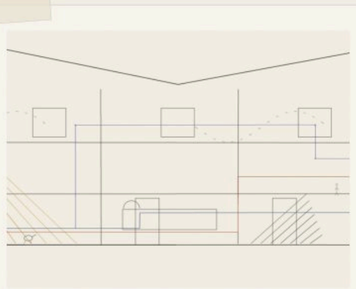


Figure 4. The far wall, for under a minute. The room is doing this whether or not anyone is in it.

Most of a life's hours are not milestones. They are preparation, maintenance, repetition, and return. Food is put away. The dog is walked. A parent calls with an update that nothing is wrong. Work is revised after the meeting. A person stands at the sink while rain moves across the yard. These intervals are easy to treat as the space between the important parts. In practice, they are what gives a life its texture. The remembered events are held in place by hundreds of days that did not announce themselves. A relationship is built as much by the repeated greeting as by the photograph chosen to represent it.

What Ordinary Leaves Out

Looking closely at an ordinary thing shows how much the word ordinary leaves out. A glass of water is plumbing, weather, geology, treatment, and a hand lifting it from the table. A tree beside the sidewalk is sunlight held in wood, roots working through compacted soil, insects using the bark, and years recorded without numbers. None of these descriptions replaces the glass or the tree. They add depth to what remains directly in front of us. Explanation is not the end of wonder. The visible thing can be understood as a surface where many processes have arrived at once.



The room, and everything running through it.

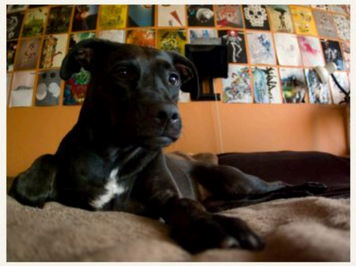
Attention cannot keep all of those processes present, and it should not. A nervous system that treated every hum, shadow, and pressure change as new would be unable to finish breakfast. Familiarity lowers the volume so action can continue. The cost is that whole systems disappear while they are working well. Electricity becomes a switch. Clean water becomes a faucet. A loved person becomes the sound of movement in another room. Their reliability lets them recede. Then a failure, an absence, or a deliberate pause makes the supporting structure visible again. The aim is not permanent intensity. It is the ability to let one familiar thing return to the foreground before loss is the only force strong enough to bring it back.

Earth turns once relative to the Sun in 24 hours and travels around the Sun at roughly 29 to 30 kilometers per second. Stillness at human scale occurs inside continuous planetary motion.

What a Relationship Is Made Of

Other people cannot be fully known. They carry private rooms of memory, worry, and attention that can be approached but never occupied. Love does not remove that distance. It makes the distance matter. A person can be known through habits, stories, expressions, and years of shared decisions, while still remaining more than the version held in another mind. This is why presence matters in such ordinary forms. Listening through the end of a sentence. Sitting nearby without improving the silence. These acts do not make a relationship permanent. They are what it is made of while it lasts.

No instruction can make a person notice everything in time. Attention wanders. Days are wasted. Familiar voices are answered impatiently. Beauty is missed because a notification arrives or because the mind is occupied with something real. The demand for perfect presence would turn noticing into another failure to manage. A smaller practice is enough. One thing returns. A patch of light is seen moving. The route around the lake feels different in wind. A machine's hum becomes audible after years in the room. The world does not need continuous appreciation to be real. It needs only occasional openings through which the ignored detail can be admitted again.



Resting, and not in charge of most of it.

A dog lies in a rectangle of afternoon light on the floor. The bright edge moves slowly across the boards. When it reaches her back, she stands, turns once, and settles inside the warmer part. The light has traveled from the Sun for about eight minutes. The floor is rotating with Earth, and the house is moving around the Sun. Air enters through a vent. Water waits under pressure inside the wall. The still room is a meeting place for motions too large, small, or familiar to hold attention for long. The dog finds the useful part and closes her eyes.

Then the light leaves the floor, and she remains where she was, now resting in shadow. In the kitchen, water runs long enough to fill a pot. Someone outside calls to another person across the street. A plane passes above the roof without appearing between the branches. None of these events asks to be kept. Most will be gone before the room is dark. Their disappearance does not make them incomplete. They occurred inside the available bracket and altered what followed by a small amount.

The pot will boil while the dog wakes. Someone will call a name from the next room. While we are here, we answer when we can.

While we are here, we answer when we can.

The pot will boil while the dog wakes.



An Año Viejo — the old year, built as a figure — waiting in the street. Tunja, Colombia, 31 December, 18:20.



Burned at midnight, so that the year goes with it. 1 January, 00:09.

HANDED OVER

Before a book becomes an object in the world, it is something one person makes and hands to another.

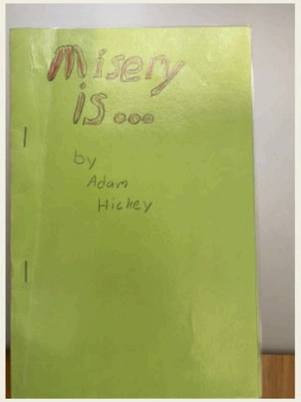


01

To the Love of My Life

Made by Fabiola. One copy, for one reader.

PHOTOGRAPHED 20 JUNE 2017, 2:39 P.M.



02

Misery Is...

Written and bound by the author as a child, and kept. Inside, in pencil: “Misery is when your mom embarrass younn front of your friends.”

PHOTOGRAPHED 4 OCTOBER 2021, 1:56 P.M.

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You can walk around a familiar lake believing almost nothing is happening. while simultaneously moving through thousands of invisible systems.



Essays on attention, on order that arrives with nobody holding a plan, on living inside a change while its rules are still unsettled, and on the ordinary shared days that turn out to be the whole thing. Four of them, meant to be read in order — each about the length of a walk.

LOOK CLOSER. STAY CURIOUS. BE KIND.